During my one-on-one with the military leaders, Sr Gen Min Aung Hlaing and Vice Senior General Soe Win, we discussed various avenues for furthering defence cooperation. Both the Generals were full of appreciation for the conduct of Operation Sunrise under my stewardship as Army Commander, Eastern Command. My having been the DA in Myanmar of course helped immensely. In fact, Vice Senior General Soe Win had been the Commander of the Northern Regional Command at Myitkyina when I was the DA, and it was he who had organized my visit to Kambaiti Pass on the Myanmar–China border and towards Pangsau on the old Stilwell Road.

I have always felt that the power of military diplomacy remains underutilized. It is time we looked at a military-diplomatic corps, by seconding officers to the Foreign Service, where they can be permanently absorbed. This would also be another form of lateral induction, particularly for officers who have been on deputation abroad either as DAs or as part of UN missions. For example, Maj Gen JS Menon, who had been a UN observer in Mozambique, has been heading the UN Disengagement Observer Force since February 2016. The expertise of Army, Navy and Air Force officers is not being made full use of. The proposed expansion of the IFS would benefit us greatly, through the induction of former Defence Attachés.

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Oting Incident

In December 2021, thirteen locals lost their lives in Oting, causing a significant blow to the peace process in Nagaland. This tragic incident occurred in the backdrop of a stabilized security situation, achieved due to persistent efforts of many